"My body and its desires are shameful."

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Where it often comes from

Being shamed as a child about your body, appearance, or normal curiosity. Teaching that treated the body as evil and only the soul as good. Silence or embarrassment about sex, hunger, rest, or pleasure. Past abuse or misuse that left you feeling dirty. Cultural messages that criticize your shape, size, or looks.

What Scripture teaches

God created the human body and called it very good. You are fearfully and wonderfully made. Your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit, bought at a price, and meant to glorify God. Natural desires such as hunger, rest, and closeness are gifts from God, to be received with thanksgiving and guided by His Word. Sin can misuse good desires, but the body and its God-given desires are not shameful in themselves.

> *"I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well"* **(Psalm 139:14)**.

Also see

> "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day" **(Genesis 1:31)**.

> "Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body" **(1 Corinthians 6:19–20)**.

> "For every creation of God is good, and nothing that is received with thanksgiving should be rejected, because it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer" **(1 Timothy 4:4–5)**.

> "And the man and his wife were both naked, and they were not ashamed" **(Genesis 2:25)**.

Common self-statements

- My body is something to be ashamed of.
- Having desires makes me sinful.
- God only cares about my soul.
- I hate the way I was made.
- Pleasure is always wrong.
- I need to punish or ignore my body.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing the body is either perfect or entirely shameful.
- **Overgeneralization:** Treating all desire as sinful because some desires can be misused.
- **Labeling:** Calling your body "dirty" or "ugly."
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding "I feel ashamed, so my body must be shameful."
- **Mental filter:** Overlooking what God says about how He made you.

Challenging questions

- What did God say about His creation, including the human body?
- If I am fearfully and wonderfully made, who taught me to be ashamed?
- Is my body a temple to be honored or a prison to be punished?
- Can a desire be good while still needing God's guidance?
- Does Scripture say to reject God's good gifts or receive them with thanks?
- Am I confusing what was done to me with who I am?
- How would I treat my body if I saw it as God's temple?

Truth summary

> My body is not shameful. God made it, called it very good, and made me fearfully and wonderfully. My body is a temple of the Holy Spirit. My natural desires are gifts from God, to be received with thanks and guided by His Word. I can honor God with my body instead of being ashamed of it.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Guilt/Shame
- God, Creator
- Sex, Normal
- Thankful

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My body and its desires are shameful"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My body and its desires are shameful." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did God say about the body He made?
- ☐ Who taught me to be ashamed of my body?
- ☐ Is my body a temple or a prison?
- ☐ Can a desire be good and still need guidance?
- ☐ Does God want me to reject His gifts or give thanks?
- ☐ How would I treat a temple of the Holy Spirit?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ God called the body He made very good.
- ☐ My body is a temple of the Holy Spirit.
- ☐ My natural desires are gifts to be guided, not shamed.
- ☐ I can honor God with my body.
- ☐ What God created, I can receive with thanks.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 139:14**
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- [ ] **Genesis 1:31**
  "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day."
- [ ] **1 Corinthians 6:19–20**
  "Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body."
- [ ] **1 Timothy 4:4–5**
  "For every creation of God is good, and nothing that is received with thanksgiving should be rejected, because it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer."
- [ ] **Genesis 2:25**
  "And the man and his wife were both naked, and they were not ashamed."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Thankful body log:** Each day, thank God for one thing my body did for me, such as walking, hugging, tasting, or healing.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 139:14 becomes: "I praise You, for **Sarah** is fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Stand in front of a mirror and read Psalm 139:13–16 aloud,** then name one part of your body you can thank God for.
- ☐ **Do one kind thing for your body this week,** such as rest, a healthy meal, or a walk, as an act of honoring God.
- ☐ **Write down one shaming message about your body** you heard growing up, and next to it write what God says.
- ☐ **Talk with a counselor or trusted believer** if past hurt has made your body feel dirty.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My body and its desires are shameful": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing my body did that I'm thankful for
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My body and its desires are shameful.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Creator God, thank You for making me fearfully and wonderfully. Help me reject the lie that my body and its desires are shameful. Teach me to see my body as Your temple, to receive Your good gifts with thanks, and to honor You with how I live. Heal any shame others placed on me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.